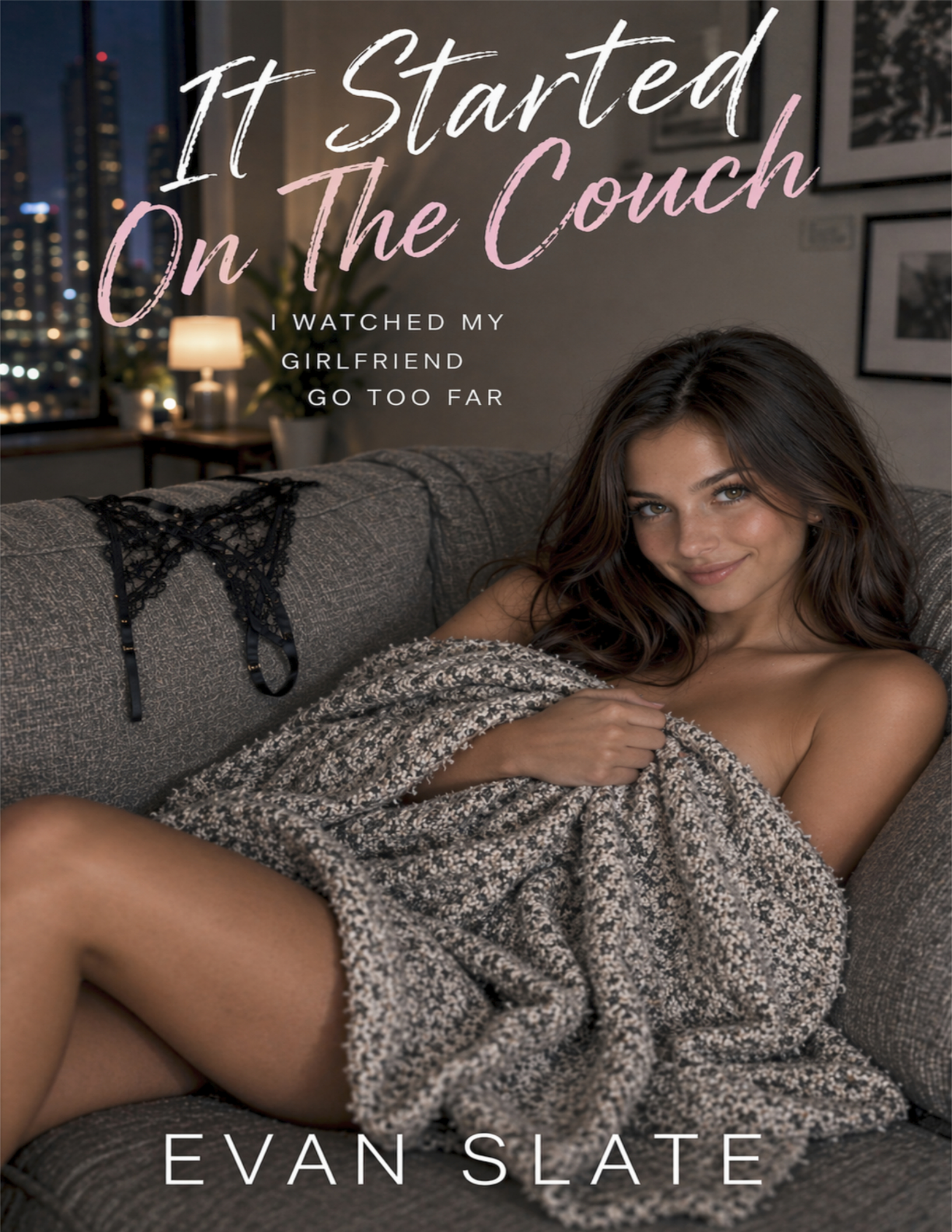




It Started On The Couch

I WATCHED MY
GIRLFRIEND
GO TOO FAR

EVAN SLATE

IT STARTED ON THE COUCH

I watched my girlfriend go too far

Evan Slate

PMI

The cabinet handle had been loose forever, one of those things you notice every time you open it and then forget about the second you close it. I was kneeling on the linoleum with a screwdriver, the handle in one hand and the screw I'd dropped twice pinched between my fingers, when Jade asked me something about Foucault from the couch.

"What's the difference between power and discipline again?" she said without looking up from her laptop.

"No idea," I said, fitting the screw back into the stripped hole and hoping it would catch this time.

"You took political theory."

"I took it pass-fail and showed up half the time."

She made a noise like she was thinking about that, or pretending to think about it, and went back to typing. The apartment was quiet in that basement way where you could hear everything happening above you, footsteps crossing a floor, a door closing, the muffled punch of music turned down low. Our place was a garden unit, which was the polite term for a basement with windows at sidewalk level that showed you the knees and boots of people walking past but never their faces. The ceiling was low enough that I'd cracked my head on the hanging light fixture twice in the first month. Jade had done it once and now moved through the space with this automatic duck anytime she stood up fast.

I got the screw in and tested the handle. It held. I stood up and opened the cabinet to feel it work smoothly and then closed it again.

"Fixed," I said.

Jade looked up for half a second, said, "My hero," and went back to her screen.

That was us. Comfortable in a way that didn't require much. We'd been together since sophomore year, living together since last summer when we found this place for cheap because nobody else wanted to live in a basement. Jade had a system for her schoolwork that involved spreading out

on the couch with her legs tucked under her and her laptop balanced on her knees. I had a system for staying out of her way when she was in that mode, which mostly meant sitting at the kitchen table with my own laptop doing problem sets or pretending to.

The tap in the bathroom dripped, a slow rhythmic plink every four seconds that you couldn't hear unless you were paying attention and then couldn't stop hearing once you noticed. I went into the bathroom and opened the cabinet under the sink looking for the shutoff valve. There wasn't one. I turned the faucet tighter, which didn't help. Then stood staring at it like that might solve something.

"Ryan, seriously, do you remember anything about Discipline and Punish?" Jade called from the other room.

"Panopticon," I called back.

"What about it?"

"That's the only thing I remember."

I heard her laugh, a short exhale through her nose. The sound of her typing picked up again. I gave up on the faucet and came back out into the main room. Jade had her pen between her teeth now, scrolling with one hand and holding the pen with the other, her face lit blue from the screen. The half-windows at street level were dark. It was past eight.

Then boots came down the stairs outside, and a knock on the door that was loud and loose.

I opened it and Julio was standing there, filling the frame in the way tall people do, his coat unzipped and his hair wet from a shower or the rain. He lived upstairs.

"Hey, man," he said. He reached out to fist bump me.

"Hey," I said, stepping back. "Come in."

He came in the way he always came in, he'd been enough times he didn't need to wait. He dropped onto the couch next to Jade, who looked up and immediately smiled.

"Julio," she said, closing her laptop halfway.

"Jade," he said back, pulling off his coat and tossing it onto the arm of the couch. "What you working on so late?"

"Poli-sci paper. And it's terrible."

"What's it about?"

"I genuinely couldn't tell you at this point."

He laughed, and she laughed too. I sat down in the chair across from them and felt the room suddenly shift into a new gear the way it always did when Julio showed up. He had that effect, where a space that had been quiet suddenly wasn't, not because he was loud but because his presence took up room and made things around it.

"You still doing the Foucault thing?" he asked.

"How do you even know that?" Jade said and she grinned and shook her hair down.

"You told me last week."

"I did?"

"Yeah, you were complaining about your professor."

Jade looked pleased that he remembered. I watched her sit up a little straighter, shift her laptop to the side. Julio leaned back into the couch, one arm stretching out along the top of the cushions, his body angled toward her in that easy way people have when they're comfortable.

"Your professor's the one with the bowtie, right?" Julio said.

"Oh my god, yes," Jade said. "He wears a different one every class and I swear he thinks it's a personality."

"That's incredible."

"It's not incredible, it's depressing."

"It's incredibly depressing."

She laughed again. He grinned. I picked up my phone off the side table to have something to do. They kept talking, Jade telling some story about her seminar and Julio asking questions that made her elaborate, the two of them building off each other in a way that didn't need me to contribute, but didn't exclude me either. I looked up every so often and added something, a comment or a question. But I wasn't leading it.

Julio stayed for maybe forty minutes. At some point he asked me about my engineering project and I told him about the motor assembly problem I was stuck on. He listened in a way that seemed genuine even though I knew he didn't care about motor assemblies. Then he asked Jade if she wanted to see a video of his niece doing something funny, and she leaned over to look at his phone. They both laughed at whatever it was while I sat drinking the beer I'd opened somewhere in the middle of all this.

Then he was standing, pulling his coat back on, saying he had to be up early.

"Good luck with the paper," he said to Jade.

"Good luck with your life," she said back. He grinned and headed for the door.

I stood and followed him, opening it and watching him take the stairs up two at a time, his boots loud on the concrete. I closed the door and locked it, the deadbolt sliding into place with a solid click.

When I turned around Jade was already back on the couch with her laptop open, her face lit blue again, her pen between her teeth. The apartment settled back into its quiet. I sat down at the kitchen table and opened my own laptop, and neither of us said anything about it. But she wasn't asking me questions anymore.

The knock came around seven, that same easy rhythm on our door. I looked up from the spreadsheet I'd been staring at for twenty minutes without actually reading. Jade was at the stove with a wooden spoon in one hand, her hair pulled back in a messy knot, wearing the grey sweatpants she'd changed into the second she got home and a black tank top that had a small stain near the hem from something she'd cooked last week.

"Can you get that?" she called over her shoulder. I was already standing, crossing the small space to the door.

Julio came in the same way he had before, coat off by the time he'd cleared the threshold, that easy energy filling the room immediately. He fist-bumped me, said hey to Jade across the apartment, and made his way toward the kitchen without waiting for any further invitation.

"Smells good," he said, leaning against the counter next to the stove, close enough that Jade had to shift to keep stirring.

"It's pasta," she said, not looking at him, focused on the pot.

"Yeah, but it smells like good pasta."

She smiled at that, the kind of smile that meant she was pleased even if she was trying not to show it, and kept stirring. I sat back down at the kitchen table, my laptop open in front of me, the spreadsheet still making no sense. The kitchen in our apartment wasn't really a separate room, an L-shaped counter with a stove and a sink that opened into the main living space, and from where I sat I could see both of them clearly, Julio leaning with his hip against the counter and Jade standing at the stove with the spoon moving in slow circles through the sauce.

"What are you making anyway?" He asked.

"Marinara. From scratch, because apparently I have time to do that now."

"You making the pasta from scratch too?"

"Do I look like I'm making pasta from scratch?"

"I don't know, you seem like the type."

"The type to what, be annoying about food?"

"The type to commit," he said, and she laughed, shaking her head.

I watched them from the table, not meaning to watch exactly, looking up every so often because the conversation was happening in my line of sight. Julio asked her something about her paper, the one she'd been working on last time, and she groaned and said she'd turned it in and it was terrible and she didn't want to talk about it. He asked what she was taking this semester and she listed her classes while she stirred. He listened like he actually cared, nodding and asking questions that made her elaborate.

The kitchen was small enough that when Julio shifted his weight or gestured with his hands he was close to her, their bodies occupying the same narrow strip of space between the counter and the stove. Jade didn't seem to mind. She stayed focused on the pasta, her attention split between the pot and whatever she was saying. Julio stayed where he was, leaning and talking and making her laugh in that easy way he had. He made her laugh more than I did, I was beginning to think. She blushed with him.

At one point he reached across her for the salt shaker on the counter behind the stove, his hand brushing her lower back as he leaned, a brief point of contact, his palm flat against the small of her back for maybe half a second before he grabbed the salt and straightened up again. She didn't react, didn't step away or acknowledge it, kept stirring like it hadn't happened.

But I noticed.

Dinner was at the small table that barely fit three chairs, Jade serving the pasta onto mismatched plates and Julio saying something about how this was better than anything he'd eaten all week, which made her roll her eyes but also smile and blush again. The conversation flowed easy and loose, Julio asking questions and Jade answering and me contributing too, but off to the side. He remembered things she'd told him before, small details about her professor with the bowties and her roommate from last year who she still complained about, and every time he brought something up she looked a little surprised and a little shy that he'd retained it.

We finished eating and moved to the couch, Jade and Julio sitting on opposite ends and me in the chair, the same configuration as before. Julio

stretched his arm across the back of the couch while he talked, not touching Jade but close enough, his hand resting on the cushion maybe six inches from her shoulder. She was sitting with her legs tucked under her, angled toward him, gesturing with her hands while she told some story about a guy in her seminar who wouldn't stop talking.

I watched Julio's arm on the back of the couch, the way his fingers drummed absently against the cushion, the small space between his hand and her shoulder that wasn't quite contact was close. Jade didn't seem to notice, or if she noticed she didn't care. The story kept going and Julio kept listening and I sat in the chair with my beer warming in my hand.

He left around nine that time, same easy exit as before, standing and pulling his coat on and saying something about an early class. Jade walked him to the door, said goodnight, and closed it behind him. I stayed on the chair and listened to the sound of his boots on the stairs, the footsteps fading as he went up to his place on the second floor.

Jade came back into the room and started clearing the plates from the coffee table, stacking them with a small clatter, humming something under her breath. I watched her move around the apartment, picking up the plates and carrying them to the sink, her movements easy and unhurried. I thought about saying something but didn't know what.

She ran water over the dishes and I sat in the chair, the apartment settling back into its usual quiet.

Julio started coming down more frequently after that, enough that it stopped feeling like visits and started feeling like a routine. He had his spot on the couch now, the left side. He'd drop into it the same way every time, pulling off his coat and settling in like he lived there. The three of us developed running jokes, the kind that only make sense if you were for the setup, references that built on themselves until they became their own language. Jade would say something about her bowtie professor and Julio would do this exaggerated serious face and stroke an invisible bowtie, and she'd laugh every time like it was still funny, which maybe it was or maybe it wasn't, I didn't know.

He knew where we kept the beer in the fridge and he knew Jade took her coffee with too much sugar and he knew I was having trouble with a specific problem set because I'd mentioned it once and he'd remembered. The apartment had absorbed him into its rhythms, his knock at the door as regular as the footsteps from upstairs or the hum of the refrigerator.

Then one night I noticed Jade had changed.

I'd been at the library until six, came home and found her on the couch in the same leggings and oversized sweater she'd worn to class that morning, her laptop open and her hair still in the bun she'd put it in without looking in a mirror. I went to the bathroom, but when I came out, she was gone.

She came out of the bedroom in jeans, dark ones that fit her well, and a different shirt, a grey henley that I'd seen her wear before but not recently, not around the apartment on a Wednesday night with nowhere to go. Her hair was down now, too, brushed out, and she'd done something to her face that I couldn't say but could see, some small adjustment that made her look more awake or more smooth or something.

She didn't say anything about it and I didn't ask.

She sat back down on the couch and opened her laptop again like nothing had changed. I looked at the clock on my phone and saw it was ten to eight, which was around the time Julio usually knocked.

He came down at eight exactly.

The visit was lively from the start, Jade already smiling by the time Julio had his coat off, the two of them falling into conversation before he'd even sat down. They were talking about some show they'd both been watching, a show I'd never heard of and wasn't part of. Jade was animated in a way that made her hands move while she talked, gesturing at the air like she was pulling the words out in front of her.

"You're wrong," Julio said, grinning. "That's not what happened."

"It is exactly what happened!"

"You're remembering it wrong."

"I literally watched it last night!"

"Then you weren't paying attention."

She shoved his shoulder, not hard but not soft either, her palm flat against him. He laughed and grabbed her wrist before she could pull it back, his fingers wrapping around it easily, holding her for a moment.

"Easy there," he said, still grinning, and she was laughing too, pulling back against his grip but not seriously, not like she actually wanted him to let go.

He held her wrist for maybe two seconds, maybe three. Then released it and she pulled her hand back and tucked it under her leg, still smiling, her

face flushed in a way that could have been from laughing or could have been anything.

I was on the chair with a beer, watching this from six feet away, smiling. It was playful. It was nothing. They were joking around and I was sitting like I was part of it even though I wasn't saying anything, even though the show they were talking about was one I'd never seen.

The conversation moved on, looping through topics the way it always did, Jade and Julio building on each other. At some point Jade said something about a article she'd read, some political theory thing. Julio shook his head and said she was wrong about that too.

"I'm not wrong!" she said.

"You're absolutely wrong."

"Prove I'm wrong then."

"Prove you're right."

"Fine," she said, and she leaned forward to grab her laptop off the coffee table, reaching across the space between them. Julio moved at the same time, his hands coming up to her shoulders, pushing her back into the couch before she could get there.

"Not so fast," he said, laughing, and she was laughing too, pushing against his hands, trying to get past him, but he held her there, his palms firm on her shoulders, keeping her pinned to the cushions while she squirmed and protested and laughed.

This lasted maybe three seconds. Then he let go and she lunged forward and grabbed the laptop, triumphant, pulling it into her lap and opening it with exaggerated intensity while Julio leaned back grinning, his hands up in mock surrender.

"You're such an ass," she said, but she was smiling.

"You love it," he said.

She didn't disagree.

I watched the whole thing with that same smile on my face, the smile that said I was in on the joke, that I thought it was funny too, that this was all part of the easy rhythm we'd fallen into. I took a sip and it tasted flat.

Julio left around ten that night, about the same as always, pulling his coat on and saying something about needing to finish a paper. Jade walked him to the door and I stayed in the chair, listening to the sound of their voices at the threshold, too low to make out the words. Then the door closed and the lock clicked into place.

She came back into the room still smiling, that energized look still on her face, and started talking about something Julio had said earlier, some joke I'd missed or some reference I didn't get, her words coming fast and tumbling over each other in a way that made it hard to follow.

"Yeah," I said.

She kept talking, pacing a little now, gesturing with her hands. I watched her move through the place, this person I'd lived with for months who suddenly seemed more animated than usual, like the apartment had gotten smaller or she had gotten larger.

"Uh-huh," I said.

She finally stopped, looked at me, asked if I was even listening.

"Yeah," I said again. "Or course I'm listening."

She smiled, somewhat satisfied, and sat back down on the couch, pulling her laptop into her lap, her face still flushed, still alive in a way I hadn't seen before I sat in the chair watching her and saying nothing at all.

The next visit started the same as the others, Julio coming down around eight and settling into his spot on the couch while Jade was mid-sentence about something that had happened in her seminar. I was in the kitchen getting a drink when I heard her say something about her playlist, the one she'd been working on all week. Julio made a sound like he was physically pained.

"That's the most basic shit I've ever heard," he said.

"It's not basic!" Jade said. I could hear the smile in her voice, the kind that meant she was gearing up to defend something she didn't actually care that much about but would argue for anyway because the argument itself was fun.

"It's aggressively basic," Julio said. "Like, that's the playlist they play at a grocery store."

"You don't even know what's on it."

"I know enough."

I came back into the room with my drink and sat down in the chair, watching the two of them on the couch, Jade with her phone in her hand pulled up to her chest like she was protecting it and Julio leaning toward her with that grin on his face that said he was enjoying this a lot.

"Name one song," she said.

"I don't need to name one song, I can feel it in my soul."

"You're so full of shit." She pressed her foot into his thigh.

"Play it then, prove me wrong."

She did, pulling up the playlist on her phone and connecting it to the speaker on the shelf. The first song that came on was something I recognized, something that had been overplayed six months ago and was still getting overplayed now. Julio pointed at the speaker like he'd won something.

"See?" he said. "Basic."

"It's a good song," Jade said.

"It's a song people pretend to like because everyone else likes it."

"Or maybe people actually like it."

"Nobody actually likes it, Jade."

She shoved him harder than she had before, her foot against his side. He rocked back into the couch laughing. She was laughing too, but was an edge to it now, a playful kind of annoyance that meant she was about to escalate. I sat in the chair with my beer watching it unfold.

Julio grabbed both her wrists before she could shove him again, his hands wrapping around them easily, and she tried to twist away but he held on, pulling her toward him instead of letting her go. She was laughing and fighting it, her whole body twisting as she tried to pull free. He was laughing too, not letting go, his grip firm but not rough.

"Let go!" she said, still laughing, her voice pitched higher from the effort of trying to get loose.

"Not until you admit it's basic."

"Never."

He stood up, still holding her wrists, and she stood with him because she didn't have a choice. Then he stepped behind her and let go of her wrists only to wrap his arms around her waist instead, locking his hands together in front of her stomach. She shrieked, a high startled sound that turned into laughter. He lifted her off the ground, not high but enough that her feet kicked uselessly in the air for a second before he set her back down.

He didn't let go of her right away, either. His arms remained around her waist, his chin almost resting on her shoulder, both of them breathing hard from laughing. I could see her hands come up to grip his forearms like she was steadying herself or like she was holding on. The apartment felt small suddenly, the low ceiling and the narrow space between the couch and the coffee table making everything closer. I sat in the chair watching the two of

them standing in the middle of the room, Julio's arms around Jade's waist and Jade's hands on his arms, both of them catching their breath.

It lasted maybe five seconds, maybe less. Then Julio released her and stepped back and Jade straightened her shirt, her face flushed, her hair a little wild from the movement. She was still laughing, that breathless kind of laughter that comes after something physical, and she turned to look at Julio with a look that was half annoyed.

"You're such an asshole," she said, grinning widely.

"You started it," he said, grinning right back.

She rolled her eyes and sat back down on the couch, tucking her legs under her and smoothing her hair back with one hand. Julio sat down next to her, not as close as before, but close enough. And like that, the moment dissolved and they were talking normally again, the conversation picking back up like the last thirty seconds hadn't happened.

I stayed in the chair, smiling too because that's what you do, because it was funny and harmless and playing around. I took a sip of my beer and nodded along when Julio said something to me about a class we both had to take next semester. I answered and the conversation kept going. The music was playing, that same overplayed song finishing and moving on to the next.

Nobody said anything about what took place, but I noticed how long Julio had held her.

I noticed how she hadn't tried that hard to get away once he'd grabbed her, too, and how her shrieking had been laughter the whole time, how her hands had come up to hold his forearms instead of pushing them away. I noticed the way her face stayed flushed for a while after, the way she kept tucking her hair behind her ear even though it wasn't in her face, the small adjustments she made to her shirt and her position on the couch.

It was playing around. That's what I told myself sitting in the chair, watching them talk and laugh and fall back into the easy rhythm they had, the rhythm that didn't need me to contribute but let me be on the edges of it. It was playing around and it didn't mean anything, people roughhoused all the time, it was normal, it was fine.

Julio left around eleven, later than usual. Jade walked him to the door and I stayed in the chair and listened to them say goodnight, her voice still bright and energized in a way that carried across the apartment even when I couldn't make out the words. The door closed and she came back and

started picking up the beer bottles from the coffee table. I stood and helped her and we moved through the small space in our usual end-of-night routine, clearing things and turning off lights and not saying much of anything.

We got into bed and she fell asleep fast, the way she always did, her breathing evening out within minutes while I lay on my back staring at the ceiling. The room was dark except for the faint glow of streetlight coming through the half-window. I could hear the footsteps from upstairs, someone walking across the floor above us, probably Julio, probably getting ready for bed in his own apartment.

I kept replaying it in my head, that moment in the middle of the room, Julio's arms around my girlfriend's waist and her feet off the ground and the sound of her laughter filling the small space. I replayed the way he'd held her after he put her down, his chin almost on her shoulder, his arms still locked around her. And the way she'd gripped his forearms like she was holding on instead of pushing away.

It was playing around. I told myself that again and again, lying in the dark with Jade asleep beside me. I kept telling myself until I finally stopped thinking about it and let the exhaustion pull me under.

I came out of the shower around seven the following Tuesday, towel around my waist and steam following me into the main room. Jade was standing at the mirror we'd hung by the door, leaning in close with an eyeliner pencil in her hand. She was wearing jeans I recognized, dark ones that sat lower on her hips and fit her differently than the loose pairs she wore around the apartment. Also a shirt I'd seen before, but not recently, something fitted and grey that showed more of her shape than the oversized sweaters she'd been living in all week.

I stopped in the doorway of the bathroom, water still running down my neck, and watched her draw a line along her eyelid with the kind of focus that meant she didn't want to be disturbed. She didn't look at me and I didn't say anything. The silence between us felt charged, like we were both aware of it and both choosing not to break it. After a moment I went into the bedroom to get dressed, too.

When I came back out she was still at the mirror, checking herself from different angles, adjusting the way her shirt sat, smoothing her hair back behind her ears. I sat down at the table with my laptop and opened it to the problem set I'd been putting off all week, the numbers and equations

blurring together while I listened to the small sounds she made moving around the apartment, the soft scrape of her shoes on the floor, the clink of something metal being set down on the counter.

She didn't explain it and I didn't ask.

At eight exactly his knock came. Jade was at the door before I could stand, pulling it open and stepping back to let Julio in as though presenting herself to him. I watched from the table as he came through the doorway and stopped, his eyes going to her immediately, taking her in with a look that lingered.

"Looking good tonight, Jade," he said, his voice easy and direct, no question in it, a statement.

She smiled the kind of smile that reaches her eyes, and shrugged like it was nothing. "So what, felt like it," she said, and she turned her face like she was suddenly self-conscious.

"Well, it's working."

She didn't deflect or laugh it off the way she might have before. She kept smiling directly at him and moved back toward the couch. Julio followed her, pulling off his coat and dropping it onto the chair I wasn't sitting in, my usual spot now taken up by his jacket and my presence pushed further to the margins.

The visit started the way they always did, conversation flowing easily, Jade and Julio falling into their rhythm while I sat at the table half-listening and half-watching. At some point Jade pulled out her phone to show Julio something, some meme or tweet or video she thought was funny. He reached for it, trying to grab it out of her hand, and she pulled it away laughing, standing up and moving around the coffee table to get away from him. She wanted to show him her phone, not give it to him.

He half chased her the way you rouse a pet, not aggressively, not fast, but with that playfulness he had, following her around the small space while she dodged and laughed, holding her phone above her head like that would keep it safe.

The apartment wasn't big enough for much of a chase. She made it maybe six steps before he caught her around the waist from behind, his arms sliding around and locking across her stomach the way they had before, and she shrieked with laughter, still holding the phone up over her head and away even though was no point anymore.

He walked her backward toward the couch, still holding her, her feet barely touching the ground as he moved her, and when his calves reached the front of the couch, he sat down and pulled her down with him, his arm still around her waist, keeping her next to him on the cushions.

She was breathless from laughing, her face flushed, and she stayed for a moment catching her breath, his arm around her middle, before she finally shifted and slid out from his grip on her, moving onto the couch but not far away, not to the chair or away from him, enough space to not be in his lap.

I watched from the table, my laptop still open in front of me, the problem set still unsolved, my hands resting on the keys without typing. The whole thing had taken maybe thirty seconds, but it felt longer, the way moments do when you're watching them with keen interest and can't look away.

They settled back into talking, Jade tucking her legs under her and Julio leaning back with one arm stretched along the top of the couch, not touching her but closer this time, his hand resting on the cushion near her shoulder. The roughhousing had left her hair messed up and her shirt askew, and she fixed both absently while she talked, her hands smoothing and adjusting without her seeming to think about it.

Later, maybe twenty minutes after that, Julio pulled out his phone to show her something, some video he'd been talking about, and she leaned in to see the screen, her head close to his, their shoulders touching. He tilted the phone so she could see better and his other hand came to rest on her knee, casual and easy, his palm flat against her jeans while he scrolled with his thumb.

She didn't move away. She didn't shift her leg or push him away or acknowledge it at all, kept watching the video with her head close to his and his hand on her knee. I sat at the table watching this from ten feet away, the distance between us feeling like it was through the wrong end of binoculars, like the apartment had reorganized itself around them and left me outside the frame.

The video ended and Jade laughed at something in it. Julio's hand stayed on her knee for another few seconds before he pulled it away to put the phone back in his pocket, the movement smooth and unremarked upon, like it had been nothing, like hands on knees were part of how they were now, together.

The visit went on, the conversation looping through topics I contributed to here and there, my voice joining theirs in a way that felt increasingly like I was a guest in my own apartment, welcomed but not necessary. Julio stayed until almost eleven, later than he usually did, and when he finally stood and pulled his coat back on Jade stood too, walking him to the door while I stayed at the table, my laptop still open, the work still not done.

I heard them talking at the door, their voices low. Then Jade said, "See you Thursday," not as a question, but a statement. Julio said, "Yeah, Thursday," and I registered that she knew, that she had his schedule in her head the same way she had her class times and her deadlines, that Thursday had become a fixed point she was oriented around.

The door closed and she came back into the room, still smiling, her face still carrying that flush from earlier, and she sat down on the couch and pulled out her phone, scrolling through something with her hair falling forward over a shoulder. I looked at her from the table and thought about saying something, asking why she'd dressed up or what Thursday meant or if she'd noticed Julio's hand on her knee, but the words didn't form and the moment passed and I turned back to my laptop and pretended to work.

She fell asleep before me that night, the same as always. I lay in bed staring at the ceiling and thinking about the way Julio had walked her backward to the couch, his arms around her waist, the way she'd stayed in his grip catching her breath before sliding away. And the way his hand had rested on her knee like it belonged there, like it was the most natural thing in the world.

Thursday came and Julio knocked at eight like clockwork, and by the time I opened the door Jade was already off the couch, already moving toward him with that smile that had become familiar, the one that started before he'd even entered the room. He had Chinese food in plastic bags, the containers still warm. The three of us ate at the coffee table with the TV on low and music playing from the speaker, some playlist Julio had put on that Jade said she liked. I watched the way she leaned toward him when she laughed, the way her whole body oriented in his direction even when she was talking to both of us.

I was noticing everything now, the way her voice changed when she addressed him versus when she addressed me, lighter with him, quicker, like the words came easier, the way she sat with her legs tucked under her on the couch, angled so she was facing him more than facing forward, her

body making a choice about where its attention belonged. I was the observer, present but peripheral, the one mostly watching.

Roughhousing started over nothing, some comment Julio made about Jade's taste in something, movies or music or food, I wasn't paying attention to catch what, and she shoved his shoulder the way she did now, the gesture automatic. He grabbed her wrist and pulled her toward him. She was whooping and laughing and trying to twist away. It escalated from there, the two of them moving around the small space with an ease that looked practiced even though it wasn't, even though this was all still supposedly spontaneous and harmless. Jade seemed to really enjoy it, Julio seemed to really watch her enjoy it.

It ended with her back on the couch and him finally letting go, both of them breathing hard and grinning at each other, a fragile and charged detente between them.

I sat in the chair with my container of fried rice going cold in my lap and told myself this was how they played around, that some people were physical like this, that it didn't mean anything beyond what it looked like on the surface.

A little while later, Jade said something teasing and Julio lunged for her. She shrieked and tried to scramble away but the couch wasn't big enough and he caught her body easily, his hands going to her ribs, tickling her, and she was shrieking louder now, squirming and trying to get away. He followed her down the cushions, pinning her with his weight, his hands moving up her sides while she thrashed and laughed and begged him to stop, but not really.

He got her wrists and grabbed both of them and pulled them up over her head, holding them with one hand while the other remained tickling her ribs. She was under him now, her back pressed into the couch and her legs kicking uselessly at his body, her face turning side to side, his face right above hers. The shrieking had turned to breathless laughter, the kind that's half running out of air.

I watched motionless and silent from the chair. My mouth almost opened. I felt the shape of words forming, something like "Hey" or "Okay" or "That's enough," something that would stop it or at least acknowledge it, make it a thing that was happening instead of a thing we were all pretending wasn't. But the words didn't come and the moment passed. Julio let her go, releasing her wrists and falling back. Jade gasped and sat up, her face

flushed, her hair wild, her chest rising and falling hard as she tried to catch her breath. Her eyes were wide and wild at him.

She fixed her hair with both hands, smoothing it back, and straightened her top. She looked at Julio with a look that was only half annoyed. He was grinning at her unapologetically. She said in a low growl, "I so hate you," but she was smiling when she said it.

They settled back into talking, the conversation resuming its flow. I sat with the words still unformed in my mouth, swallowed back down. I told myself it was fine, it was playing around, it didn't mean what I thought it could mean if I let myself think about it too much.

Later, when the food was gone and the containers were stacked on the coffee table and the music had shifted to something slower, Julio reached over and grabbed Jade's legs, pulling them across his lap like it was the most natural thing in the world, like this was how they sat now. She let him, too, didn't resist or pull away, shifted her weight and settled into it. His hand came to rest on her shin, his palm warm against her jeans, his thumb moving in small absent circles, occasional squeezes.

They kept talking, something about a class they were both taking or a professor they both had, I wasn't following closely enough to track it. I watched his hand on her leg, watched it slide up to her knee, then higher to her thigh, resting there, and she didn't move, didn't shift her legs or pull them back, kept talking and gesturing with her hands while his hand remained on her thigh, solid and present and impossible to ignore. She seemed to stretch her legs out more, to sink deeper into the couch.

I told myself this was how they both were, physical and comfortable with it, that it didn't mean anything, that she was enjoying the attention in a harmless way, that I was reading too much into it because I was tired or stressed or overthinking the way I always did. I told myself that if it meant something she would say so, or I would say something, or someone would acknowledge that this had crossed some line. But nobody was saying anything so maybe was no line, maybe this was what normal looked like and I was the one making it weird by sitting here cataloging every touch and every laugh and every moment of contact.

Julio left around midnight after we watched a movie, Jade's legs over Julio's lap the whole time, though was a blanket over them most of it. The door closed and the apartment was quiet again. Jade came back and started

cleaning up the containers, her face still carrying that brightness that seemed to last longer each time.

We got ready for bed, brushing teeth and changing clothes and moving through the small space without saying much, and when we lay down she fell asleep almost immediately.

I lay awake, staring at the ceiling, replaying the moment on the couch, Julio's hands on her wrists and her body under his and the sound of her breathless laughter. Then later, his hand on her thigh and her leaving it there. I told myself tomorrow I would say something, tomorrow I would ask her what was happening or tell her I'd noticed, but even as I thought it I knew I wouldn't, knew I'd wake up and the moment would feel less urgent and I'd talk myself out of it the way I'd been talking myself out of it for weeks now.

I told myself tomorrow I'd say something. Then I lay in the dark listening to her breathe and knowing I wouldn't.

Julio came down with a six-pack and Jade was already on the couch, the music playing low from the speaker on the shelf. I was in the kitchen getting glasses and by the time I came back they were already mid-conversation about something, their voices overlapping in that easy way they had developed, batting away each other's hands reaching for each other's mouths, they both had things to say on top of each other. I sat down in the chair and opened my beer and let the evening settle into its now familiar rhythm.

We talked about nothing important, the kind of conversation that fills time, Jade telling some story about her seminar and Julio asking questions that made her elaborate. I sat drinking and listening and watching the way they moved around each other even when they were sitting still, arms and hands entwining, covering mouths, falling into each other's laps.

At some point Julio reached for the remote on the coffee table, saying something about the playlist being repetitive. Jade said it wasn't repetitive it was curated. He said that was a word people used when they didn't want to admit they had bad taste, and she laughed and grabbed the remote before he could get to it, holding it away from him over her head.

"My apartment, my music," she said, grinning.

"Technically Ryan's apartment too," Julio said, glancing at me. I shrugged because I didn't care about the music and didn't want to be pulled into this.

"Ryan doesn't care," Jade said, which was true.

"Then let me pick something."

"No."

He reached for the remote again, leaning across the couch toward her, and she twisted away, holding it behind her back. He kept reaching, his body coming across hers now, his chest pressing against her shoulder as he stretched for it. She was laughing and blocking him with her free hand, pushing at his chest. He shifted his weight and ended up half on top of her, one hand braced on the back of the couch and the other still reaching for the remote she was holding out of his reach.

They froze like that, his body pressing hers into the cushions, his weight on her, his face maybe six inches from hers. They were both still smiling but the laughter had stopped. There was a moment, two seconds, maybe three, where neither of them moved and the air in the room became something heavier, something that made my chest tighten even though I was sitting watching.

He didn't move immediately. She didn't push him off. They stayed like that, his body on hers, her hand still holding the remote out to the side, her other hand resting on his chest where she'd been pushing him up but wasn't pushing anymore. Her fingers curled into his shirt. I could see her breathing, the rise and fall of it from laughing. Or not.

He pulled back, easy and smooth, his hands coming up in mock surrender, his grin returning like the moment hadn't happened.

"Alright, you win," he said, sitting back into his spot on the couch. Jade sat up, her hand going to her shirt to straighten it, her face flushed in a way that could have been from the struggle or could have been from anything.

Nobody said anything about it.

The conversation picked back up, Jade saying something about the song that was playing and Julio responding and me sitting in the chair two feet away watching this and saying nothing, my beer warm in my hand and my throat tight with words I didn't know how to form.

Fifteen minutes later they were talking about a show they'd both been watching, something I hadn't seen. I noticed Julio's arm had moved, stretched across the back of the couch behind Jade's shoulders, fingers touching her there lightly across the back of her neck. And then he was resting his hand on her shoulder, casual and easy, and she still didn't move away, didn't shift or create space, just kept talking and gesturing with her

hands while she leaned into him on his pull of her shoulder, her body angled toward his, the two of them close in a way that looked like it had always been that way even though it hadn't. His fingers slid under the line of her top, touched her down her back, under her hair.

I sat in the chair across from them, the coffee table between us. The geometry of the room felt very clear suddenly. Them on the couch, together, his arm fully around her now and her body leaning into his, me in the chair, separate, outside of it, watching.

They kept talking and I kept sitting there silently. At some point I stopped following the conversation entirely, watched the way his fingers moved absently over her shoulder, the way she laughed at something he said, the laugh sounding different, fuller and lighter. His hand sometimes entirely slid down her back under her top. She curled into him, went "mmm" and leaned back to trap his hand against her a moment, but laughed too, disarming the moment.

I didn't know what it was at first, but she startled, he laughed and withdrew his hand quickly, and she chicken winged her arms up her back and flooded red in her face, before she slapped his hand.

Julio stood and pulled his coat on and said, "Night guys," casual and easy like nothing, like the last two hours had been the same as every other time. Jade stood too, walked him to the door while I remained in the chair with my hands in my lap. I realized he must have unclasped her bra then, a joke.

I heard them talking at the door, their voices too low to make out the words. Then the sound of the door opening and closing and the lock clicking into place. I expected Jade to come back into the room the way she always did, to sit back down on the couch or start cleaning up, but she didn't.

She walked straight past the living room to the bedroom without saying anything. I heard the door close behind her, not a slam but firm enough. I sat in the chair in the quiet apartment with the music still playing low and the empty bottles on the coffee table and the shape of where they'd been sitting still visible in the cushions.

I don't know how long I remained sitting and staring at nothing and trying to figure out what I was supposed to do with what I'd seen, what I was supposed to say, whether I was supposed to say anything at all or if

saying something would make it worse, would make it real in a way it wasn't real yet as long as nobody spoke about it.

Eventually I stood and turned off the music and the lights and went to bed. Jade was already there with her back to the door, her breathing even in a way that meant she might have been asleep or might have been pretending. I got in beside her without saying anything and lay in the dark and the sound of footsteps from upstairs, Julio moving around in his place. I thought about tomorrow, about saying something, about asking her what was happening, or telling her I'd noticed the thing that was sitting between us now like a growing weight. At least for me it was.

But I knew I wouldn't. I knew I'd wake up and I'd find a reason to put it off. The next day would come and I'd sit in the chair again and watch again and say nothing. The pattern would continue until something broke or didn't break. I didn't know which outcome I was more afraid of.

I came home at five and found Jade in the bathroom with the door open, standing at the mirror with her hair wet and a towel wrapped around her. She had music playing from her phone on the counter, something I didn't recognize, and I glanced at her phone and noticed it was Julio's playlist. She was leaning close to the mirror doing something to her eyes with a small brush, her hand steady and her focus complete.

I stopped in the doorway and watched her for a moment, the careful way she drew the line along her eyelid, the way she stepped back to check her work and then leaned in again to adjust it. I knew without asking that Julio would be down around eight, that this was for him, that the hours between now and then would be filled with this taut wordless preparation.

I went to the kitchen and opened the fridge and stared into it without knowing what I was looking for, and when I closed it and turned around she was hurrying past me to the bedroom in her towel.

By seven she was dressed, sitting on the couch with her phone. I tried not to look directly at her but I saw it anyway, a short skirt that fit her in a way that made you notice and a top that was, black and low-cut, showing the line of her collarbone and the shape of her in a way that felt calculated, that felt like a choice made with someone specific in mind.

I sat at the table with my laptop pretending to work. The apartment was quiet except for the occasional sound of her shifting on the couch. The silence between us felt heavy, like we were both waiting for the same thing and both pretending we weren't.

“You know,” I said, looking up as though I just thought of something. “Julio, he’s down here sometimes it seems every night.”

“Such a funny guy,” she replied, not looking up.

“Practically lives here now,” I half joked.

She put her phone down and came into the kitchen for water. “I think he likes it better down here than his place up there,” she said and she chuckled.

“You guys certainly get alone, horsing around like that.”

“It doesn’t bother you,” she said.

“No,” I agreed and I watched her sashay back into the living room and slide back down onto the couch, stretching her legs out over the coffee table. “Lots of it though.”

“That’s just who he is,” she said without looking up, her eyes back on her phone. “He’s a physical man,” she said in a funny southern voice.

“Reaching down your back and everything.”

“Oh come on! Julio?”

“He’s just being funny, I know,” I said and I chuckled too.

She cocked her head and drew her phone away from her face to find me with her deep, dark, and lined eyes, bright and sparkling. I think she put some sparkly on her upper cheeks. “We’re just friends, you know that. He’s your friend too.”

I nodded and she went back to her phone, put his music up louder. She laughed at something, dropped her phone and dashed to the door.

He didn’t need to knock, he must have texted her. Before I could even lift my face from my screen, she was yanking it open and stepping back. Julio came in and stopped, his eyes going to her immediately, taking her in from head to toe in a way that wasn’t subtle, that didn’t even try to be. She twirled around for him, her skirt flaring out, and she laughed with a squeal.

“I know you like this one,” she said like a dare.

“Damn, Jade,” he said, his voice low and appreciative, and she smiled, not so shy anymore, not deflecting.

He pulled off his coat and moved into the room. I could feel it immediately, the charge in the air, the way the space felt different, tighter and more electric, like something was already happening before anything had actually happened.

We ended up on the couch, all three of us this time, which didn’t happen often because the couch wasn’t big enough for three people to sit comfortably. I was on one end, Jade in the middle, Julio on the other end,

and we were talking about something, I don't even remember what, the conversation was flowing so easily and it felt almost normal, except for the way our knees kept bumping and the way there wasn't enough space. We had a doc on but we weren't really paying attention.

Julio shifted and stretched, his arm going across the back of the couch. He said something about needing more room, about how we were all crammed in like sardines, and we all laughed. Then he reached around Jade, his hands sliding down her waist, and he pulled her sideways across his lap before she could protest or agree or do anything, and she shrieked with laughter as he moved her over him. Now she was sitting across his thighs sideways, her legs draped down between his, his arm around her back to steady her.

"There," he said, grinning. "Problem solved, right?"

She was laughing, her hands on his shoulder and his chest to balance herself. I expected her to push off and move back to where she'd been sitting, expected this to be another one of those quick moments that dissolved back into normal, but she didn't move this time. She stayed on him.

She settled back into his chest, adjusting her position to get comfortable, and kept talking, picking up the conversation where it had left off, her hands gesturing while she spoke, animated and easy. Julio's hand was on her hip, his palm flat against her, holding her. I was sitting three feet away on the other end of the couch watching my girlfriend sitting on another man's lap like it was the most natural thing in the world. I guess it was, sort of. Nobody else was particularly alarmed.

They kept talking and I kept sitting there trying not to notice too much, my mouth dry and my hands in my lap, my mind circling around the same thought over and over, that I should say something, that this was the moment to say it, but the words didn't come and the moment kept going and it started to feel like if I said something now it would be strange, would be making a thing out of something that everyone else was treating as nothing. The longer she remained in his lap, the more it did become normal.

Five minutes passed, maybe more, Jade sitting on Julio's lap the whole time, his hand on her hip and sometimes moving up to her lower back and under her top, or her body leaning into him when she laughed. I watched every second of it, every point of contact, every moment where she could

have moved and didn't. Her legs swung between his like someone on a Saturday afternoon swing in the park.

Finally she shifted, pushing off his chest with her hands and sliding back to her spot in the middle of the couch, casual and easy, like sitting on his lap had been no different than sitting between us. The conversation kept going without pause, without acknowledgment. I sat feeling like I'd witnessed something significant that everyone was pretending they hadn't seen.

Later, after we'd moved through another hour of talking and drinking and pointing and critiquing the documentary, Julio and Jade got into another one of their wrestling matches, this one starting lightly over something I didn't catch, and now she was standing by the speaker trying to change the show. He came up behind her slowly but she didn't move to get away. His hands slid slowly around her waist. He lifted her off the ground, and spun her around while she shrieked and laughed and kicked her feet.

He put her down but his hands remained on her waist, his fingers spread wide against her sides where her top had stretched up, and she was still laughing, breathless from it, her hands coming up to grip his forearms to hold on. They stood like that for a moment, his hands on her waist and her hands on his arms, both of them catching their breath, her not stepping away.

She remained in his grip, her body pulled close to his, close enough that I could see the rise and fall of her breathing, close enough that when she finally did step away it felt like she was pulling herself out of something too intimate. It was less like the usual horseplay, and more like something private. His hand fell away from where it was pressed flat on her stomach under her top.

I sat frozen in the chair, watching this happen, silent and still. I felt my chest tighten and release and tighten again, something that might have been anger or fear. I was paralyzed by it.

At some point Julio pulled out his phone to show Jade something, some video or meme he thought she'd find funny, and she watched it over his shoulder and then reached for the phone, saying she wanted to see it again. He pulled it away, holding it out of her reach.

"Let me see," she said, reaching across him, but she was flashing her eyes at him, too. He held it further away, grinning, and she kept reaching, climbing over him to get to it, her body now across his lap, her hand stretching out toward the phone he was holding up and away. But not so far

she couldn't get it if she really wanted it. And she wasn't trying that hard to get it, either, other than crawling over him.

"Say please," he said low and soft.

"No," she said, laughing, still reaching, but only sort of. He shifted, holding the phone above his head, and she scrambled up his body after him, her hands reaching up and him holding it higher, both of them laughing.

She reached again, her fingertips brushing his hand but not getting the phone. He was laughing at her effort, at the way she kept trying even though she had to know she couldn't reach it. She lurched one more time and then gave up, her hands coming down to shove his chest.

"You're such an ass," she said, breathless from reaching and laughing, her face flushed.

He caught her wrists before she could pull her hands away, his fingers wrapping around them easily. He pulled her toward him, closing the distance between them, and she fell forward, pulled off balance, and suddenly they were chest to chest, her wrists still in his hands, her face tilted up to look at him.

"Just say please," he said again, quieter this time. She was breathing hard, her chest rising and falling against his. She said, "I don't beg for it," but her voice had changed, had lost some of its playfulness and gained something breathier and less certain.

They remained like that for a moment longer, still and close and looking hard into each others eyes from inches apart. I was in on the couch three feet away watching this, watching them pressed together with her wrists in his hands and their faces so close. I could feel my heart starting to pound in my chest again, could feel it rising in my throat, what might have been words or might have been something else.

That's when he leaned down and kissed her.

It was quick and light, his mouth on hers, a press of lips that lasted maybe a second, maybe less. Then he pulled back grinning, his hands releasing her wrists, and she sat frozen for half a second, her eyes beaming wide, her mouth hanging open. Then she shoved him again, both hands flat against his chest.

"What the fuck!" she said, but she was laughing too, her voice pitched high with surprise or shock or something, but not anger. He leaned back with his hands up in mock surrender, but still grinning.

"What?" he said. "You looked like you wanted me to."

She stared at him for another second but then laughed, a short surprised laugh, and she shook her head and leaned back down in the couch, her hands going to her face like she was trying to hide behind them. He leaned back next to her, easy and casual again, like nothing had happened, like he hadn't just kissed her, like this was all still part of the game.

"Sorry you had to see that," she said quietly to me and she rolled her eyes like it was Julio just being Julio again.

I shrugged because I had no words. I saw it from three feet away. I watched Julio lean down and kiss my girlfriend, watched her freeze and then shove him back, but then watched her laugh it off like it was nothing, like kissing her was another joke in their ongoing back-and-forth, another part of how they played around.

My heart was pounding so hard I could feel it in my throat. My hands were gripping the edge of the couch though my face stayed normal, stayed still, stayed silent.

"You're okay?" she said privately to me.

"I don't know," I shrugged.

She turned back to him after a couple moments and began talking again, just picking up the conversation like the last thirty seconds hadn't happened, Jade saying something about the clip that had started all this and Julio responding and the two of them falling back into their usual rhythm of laughing and teasing. I leaned back with my mouth closed and my mind screaming, screaming that I should say something, should ask what the fuck that was, should tell Julio to leave or tell Jade we need to talk or do something other than sit there pretending it was normal.

But I didn't do anything. I sat and I smiled when something funny was said and acted like I hadn't just watched another man kiss my girlfriend right in front of me, like it was fine, like it was just playing around, like it didn't mean anything because they were both treating it like it didn't mean anything. If I made it a thing then I would be the one making it weird, I would be the one who didn't understand that this was how they just were, physical and playful and comfortable. It was just a kiss, after all.

But that kiss hung in the air the whole time even though nobody mentioned it, even though it had been absorbed into the general atmosphere of the evening like it was just another moment in a long string of moments. Julio's arm ended up around Jade's shoulders at some point, and she leaned into him while they talked. I watched from the chair where I'd moved to at

some point, and I saw the ease between them, the way they existed in each other's space like it had always been this way.

Later we got ready for bed in silence like we were both choosing not to break it because breaking it would mean acknowledging something we weren't ready to speak about, and when we got into bed and she fell asleep quickly like she always did, I lay staring at the ceiling with my heart still pounding and my mind replaying the moment over and over.

Him leaning down, the quick press of his mouth to hers, the way she'd froze and then laughed. And then the way she'd sat back and the conversation continuing and nobody saying anything about it because apparently there was nothing to say, it was part of how they played around now.

I was the only one who thought it might have meant something, the only one whose heart was pounding, the only one lying awake in the dark replaying it and trying to figure out what I was supposed to do about it.

Say something tomorrow, I told myself. Tomorrow you'll say something. You'll ask her what that was. You'll tell her you noticed. You'll bring up what's happening.

But even as I thought it I knew I wouldn't, knew I'd wake up and find a reason to let it go, knew the next time would come and I'd sit and watch it again and still say nothing.

I lay in the dark and listened to Jade breathe beside me and told myself tomorrow, knowing it was a lie.

Two more times had come since that kiss, two more nights of the same pattern, Julio coming down and the three of us falling into our routine, music and documentaries and beers and chattering.

More kissing had happened both times too, quick and playful, framed now as part of their teasing. I'd watched both times and said nothing both times. They'd wrestle or play or tease, their faces would come close, and he'd kiss her on the lips and they'd both laugh like it was a tickle, a pinch.

She let him, not initiating it exactly, but not alarmed by it either anymore, maybe even returning the kisses, letting them linger longer between them. It felt like a natural progression, two people who enjoyed horsing around. Kissing her was part of his manhandling her, just part of what went on between them, just being the friends they were. It was fun.

Now it was Friday again and Julio was on the couch and Jade was standing by the speaker changing the song and he said something about her

music still being terrible, and she turned and said something back. He reached out and grabbed her hand and pulled her toward him. She came easily, laughing, letting him pull her down onto his lap.

She settled on him like it was nothing, like this was where she sat now, sideways across his thighs with his arm around her waist. They kept talking closely, something about a class or a professor or some story she was telling. I was in the chair as usual watching this the way I always watched it now, silent and still, just resting, absorbing the music, entranced by the documentary scenes.

They were laughing about something that I wasn't following closely enough to know what, and mid-sentence, mid-laugh, Julio tilted her chin up, his fingers under her jaw, and he leaned in and kissed her again.

It was longer this time, longer than a quick playful press like before. His mouth remained on hers for one second, two seconds, three, and she kissed him back, I could see it, could see the way her body turned toward his, the way her hand came up to grip on his shoulder. Tongues were involved. All was silent under the throb of the music in the light of the documentary on the screen. Her fingers curled into the fabric of his top. Then she pulled away, laughing, her face flushed, her eyes flashing a glance at me.

"You're trouble," she said privately, but she was smiling when she said it, too, and she didn't get up, didn't move off his lap, but settled back deeper into him and picked up the conversation where it had left off like the last three seconds hadn't taken place.

I sat in the chair and felt my chest tighten and my throat close and my hands gripped the beer bottle harder.

Ten minutes later it happened again, Julio said something teasing, something about Jade being wrong about whatever they were talking about, and she rolled her eyes at him, exaggerated and playful.

He grabbed her face with both hands this time, his palms on her cheeks, and he kissed her deeply and long, holding her.

This time she was smiling into it, I could see the shape of her smile even with his mouth on hers, and when he pulled back she was smirking and he was grinning and they went right back to talking like this was part of how they communicated now, like kissing was punctuation in their conversation.

It was their dynamic now. Kissing was part of the playing, part of the teasing, part of the fun. It was happening in front of me, repeatedly, casually. I was sitting right there watching it and saying nothing, and with

each moment that passed it got harder to imagine saying something, harder to figure out what the something would even be by that time.

What would I say? Stop kissing my girlfriend? Except she didn't seem to want him to stop, she seemed now to be kissing him back, seemed to be enjoying it. If I said something now after all the times I'd sat there and watched it and said nothing, what would that make me? The jealous boyfriend who couldn't handle his girlfriend having a little harmless fun? The insecure one who made everything weird?

Jade remained on Julio's lap, shifting positions occasionally but not getting off him. His hands were on her the whole time, on her waist or her hip or her back, and she leaned into him while they talked, her body comfortable against his. I watched from the chair and felt paralyzed, felt like I was trapped in this position of observer, of witness to something I should be stopping but couldn't figure out how to stop. It was too late. Sometimes it was Jade who caught him mid-sentence with a kiss deep and long on his mouth, holding his face. It was how they made each other shut up, they said. But his thumb rubbed her lip and when he pressed it inside her mouth, she closed around it, sucked on it, but only for a bit.

Later, after Jade had got off his lap, they'd gotten into another of their wrestling matches, this one starting over the remote again or maybe his phone. Julio ended up on top of her on the couch, pinning her down with his weight. He kissed her while she was under him laughing and half-fighting back, his hands on her hips holding her down. She was squirming under him but not seriously, not like she actually wanted to get away. The kiss lasted longer this time, four seconds, five, and when he finally pulled back she was breathless and flushed. Her voice though, not a laugh, more like the beginning of one that dragged out.

I sat in the chair with my drink in my hand, frozen, watching this in my apartment on my couch, watching another man pin my girlfriend down and kiss her while she laughed and kissed him back, and still I did nothing. If it was still wrestling, it was slower now, closer, less a struggle and more a dance, pressed closer together.

The evening wound down eventually. Julio finally headed for the door. she came back into the room still smiling, her face still carrying that flush, that brightness that seemed to come from him and linger after he left.

I sat watching her move around the apartment, this person I'd been with some time but who now felt like a stranger at times, who felt like she was

living in some parallel version of our life where this was all normal and fine and I was the one out of step.

"You going to be okay?" she asked at some point, glancing at me.

"Yeah," I said, and my voice sounded normal, sounded like I was okay even though I wasn't, even though I felt like I was drowning in this apartment, in this situation I couldn't stop.

"You're quiet tonight," she said.

"Just tired I guess," I said. "Things going on though," I added.

She knew exactly what I was talking about. "We were just play fighting, just wrestling, you know us."

"I guess," I said.

She came up to me and tickled me under my chin. "You don't have to worry, we're just friends, you know that," she said and she raised herself on her toes to kiss my cheek.

"You were kissing," I finally got the nerve up to say.

But she turned away and tidied the counter. "Oh that?" she flubbed. "You're not jealous of a little fun, are you?"

"It's just..." I started again but I trailed off.

She laughed dismissively. "I wouldn't even call that kissing," she said. "It's just..." she turned to me and shrugged. "European."

She nodded and went back to tidying. We got ready for bed and she fell asleep quickly. I replayed the moments from the evening, the kisses and the touching and the way she'd looked at him, the way she'd kissed him back, began to imitate the kisses, even, and the way she'd seemed more alive with him in her eyes.

I got home from campus around six to find Jade already in the bathroom, the door open, music playing loud from her phone while she stood at the mirror with a curling iron in her hand, working through sections of her hair with careful precision. She was wearing a short skirt, black and fitted, shorter than anything she usually wore around the apartment, and a top that showed her shoulders and the line of her collarbone. When she leaned forward to check her makeup in the mirror I could see she'd done something different with her eyes, something darker. I could smell her scent.

I stood in the doorway watching her and she glanced at me in the mirror, a quick flick of her eyes. Then she went back to what she was doing without saying anything. I didn't say anything either. I went to the kitchen and

opened a beer I didn't want and sat at the table waiting for eight o'clock to come as it inevitably would.

When Julio came in, they moved to the couch and I took the chair, the same positions we always took now, except within ten minutes, when Jade came back from the kitchen with snacks, she turned the lights down lower than usual and she sat on his lap facing him, straddling him, her knees pushing down on either side of his hips and her skirt riding up high on her thighs. His hands went around her ass immediately, naturally, like this was where his hands belonged now.

They kept talking like this was now normal, like her straddling him on the couch while I sat six feet away was another configuration we'd fallen into. I watched his hands on her ass, watched the way his fingers gripped and released, watched the way she settled her weight onto him and leaned in close to feed him bits of snack from the bowl she brought back.

It became their new default position. She remained on his lap, facing him and they talked and laughed, her twisting to make a token attempt to pretend they were trying to watch the documentary I stared at, and at some point they started kissing, too, longer and deeper than the playful kisses from before. I could see her hands go to his face, his neck, could see the way her body arched into his, and a slow subtle grind that maybe she wasn't even aware of doing on his lap, but I could see in the much dimmer light. I could see the way his hands moved from her ass to her hips and to her lower back, holding her tighter against him.

At one point his hand slid up under her shirt, disappearing beneath the fabric. I could see the shape of it moving, his palm flat against her skin, and she didn't stop him, didn't pull away, but kept leaning him to kiss him while his hand explored her under her shirt. I sat in the chair with my beer on the side table and my heart pounding so hard I thought they might be able to hear it.

They were making out now, not kissing playfully but actually full on kissing, her mouth open against his, her hips grinding down against him in a way that was unmistakable. I could hear their breathing change, could hear it get heavier and faster. I couldn't look away, couldn't move, couldn't do anything but sit and watch. It was dark enough I could pretend that maybe I couldn't see it, and the music and documentary were loud enough too that I could pretend not to hear either.

Then Julio pulled back, his hands still on her. He looked past her shoulder at me and grinned, and he said, "We're being rude to Ryan."

Jade laughed, breathless and flushed, and slid off his lap, moving to sit next to him on the couch instead, and for a moment I thought maybe that was it, maybe that was the line, maybe they'd pulled back and would stop now.

"Are we being rude to you, brother?" he said to me a chuckle.

But his hand went immediately to her thigh, landing high up on her leg where her skirt remained ridden up.

"I don't know," I said and I laughed. "Two of you, you're always horse-playing around."

"See? Just horse-playing," Jade said to him with a wide grin, and she played her tongue along her top lip.

"Hard to tell what's going on, actually," I said.

But he didn't reply. I watched his hand slide higher, disappearing under the fabric of her skirt. She let him, didn't stop him, didn't adjust her position or pull his hand away. She leaned back into the couch and kept kept smiling, kept acting like this was normal.

They started talking about weekend plans, something about a party or a show or something, I wasn't really following, couldn't follow, because I was watching Julio's hand move higher under her skirt, watching the way his arm moved, the way his hand had to be between her legs now, had to be touching her over her underwear at least, probably, maybe under it, I couldn't tell, it was too dark. She was still talking but her breath caught once, a small hitch that maybe he noticed or maybe he didn't, but I noticed, I noticed everything.

I sat in the chair unable to look away, unable to speak, unable to do anything but watch this unfold in front of me. I felt my body responding in a way that made me sick, felt myself getting hard watching another man touch my girlfriend. I hated it and yet I couldn't stop it. I couldn't reconcile what I was feeling with what I should be feeling. My mind was screaming at me to say something, to stand up, to tell him to stop, to tell her this had gone too far. But my mouth stayed shut and my body remained still.

They kept talking about the weekend, about plans and schedules and who was doing what. Julio's hand remained between her legs and Jade kept smiling, but occasionally her breath would catch again or her eyes would

flutter closed for half a second. Then she'd keep talking like nothing was happening, like this was how Friday nights went now.

I watched her face, watched the way her expression shifted when his hand moved under her skirt, watched her try to keep her composure while he touched her, which I could tell, it was obvious now. I felt like I was floating outside my body, like I was watching this happen to someone else, like this couldn't be my life, my apartment, my girlfriend sitting on the couch with another man's hand between her legs while we all pretended to have a normal conversation. Though nobody was saying anything anymore for a while.

At some point I stood up and mumbled something about getting another beer even though I hadn't finished the one I had. I walked to the kitchen and stood with my hands on the counter staring at nothing. I could hear Jade laugh at something Julio said. I thought about walking out the door, about leaving, about going anywhere else. But I didn't.

I got a beer from the fridge and went back to the chair and sat down opposite the couch. They were still in the same position, his hand still under her skirt, her face still flushed. I watched and said nothing and the evening continued around me like I wasn't even there, like I'd become a ghost in my own apartment, present but not participating, watching but not acting. The worst part was that some part of me had accepted this, had given up on stopping it, had decided that this was what things were now. I was going to sit here and watch it because I didn't know how to do anything else.

The next time he came down, he nodded and said, "Ryan," and I nodded from the kitchen. Jade hit the lights, put on music and some documentary, and they moved together to the couch instantly. Within minutes the pretense was gone, whatever thin veneer of normalcy we'd been maintaining dissolved completely.

Earlier, she'd said, "You're still okay with him coming down, right?"

"It's just Julio."

"It's just Julio. We're just good friends, we're close, you know that, right?"

"Jade, I get it."

"We just like to horse-play, the both of us, like you said."

"It's just fun, right?"

"It's just fun," she agreed. "I can go upstairs with him though, if you want."

She looked at me with deep, wide eyes, her gaze darting back and forth between my eyes.

I knew what that probably meant. “No no, why do that?”

“In case, you know,” she said.

“Just hanging out right?”

“In case you don’t like it, in case you don’t like seeing it,” she said, scrunching up her nose. “The way we play around sometimes. Kind of getting carried away a little,” she chuckled.

“I think I can handle it,” I said, and I chuckled too.

“Because sometimes Julio says he wants to take me upstairs instead, but I told him no.”

“You mean without me?”

She laughed and rolled her eyes. “Well of course, what do you think he wants to do to me?”

“I don’t know,” I said.

“I mean it’s better at least down here, don’t you think? Unless you’d rather I go up there instead...”

“I think it would be worse up there.”

She nodded with nervousness. “I think so too,” she said in nearly a whisper.

“It doesn’t mean anything though, right?”

She laughed again and rolled her eyes some more. “No, of course not! Julio?” she laughed with a forced note. “We’re just having fun. It’s just play fighting, you know that. He’s fun to wrestle around with.”

“You like dressing up for him.”

“What, this?” she said, turning out the collar of her dress. “It’s just fun to tease him. He’s easy to tease with stuff like this. You see the way he gets with it.” She rolled her eyes again. “He’s so easy with the make-up and clothes and other things.”

Her phone buzzed and she ran to the door. While she waited to hear his steps outside, she looked over her shoulder at me. “You don’t have to watch though if it bothers you.”

“It doesn’t,” I lied.

“Because he said he wants to...” she paused. “Do things to me, like I was saying. Stupid Julio like usual.”

“Do you?”

“No!” she squealed. “Of course not. But it’s fun, sort of playing around, I like teasing him,. But if you say not to...”

But I said nothing. His footsteps came down and she pulled open our door.

He pulled Jade onto his lap and she went immediately to him, straddling him, facing him. They started kissing before she'd even settled her weight on him his hands closing around her ass and then sliding up over her dress, gripping her through the fabric first and then finding the hem and going under it, his palms on her bare skin just like that.

He leaned back deep and low into the couch and she began grinding down against him already, her hips moving in slow circles on him. I could see the shape of him growing hard beneath his jeans when the screen flashed momentarily bright, could see the way she was pressing herself down against it. I came in to sit four feet away watching this, watching my girlfriend grind herself against another man while they kissed constantly.

She twisted in his lap, looked at me. “Is it dark enough?” she said.

“For me?”

“Why don’t you turn out all the lights?” She pulled on her lip with her fingers. “So you can’t see,” she said more softly.

I got up and did so and now the only light in the place was the blue glow of the silent screen showing undersea scenes of coral.

“You should put the music up, too, maybe,” she said, before she turned back to him and cocked her head to take his mouth aggressively with hers.

I found the speaker in the dark and turned up the volume and sat back down. The new playlist was deep dark baselines, low and smooth hip hop that blended together with no transitions between songs. I sank back into my chair and pretended to watch fish dart in and around the strange formations deep underwater.

Across the room, Julio’s hands moved up my girlfriend’s back, found the tiny zipper of her dress. He pulled it down slowly, the sound of it loud in my ears. Then he was peeling her dress up and over her head and she raised her arms to help him. The dress came off and landed on the floor beside the couch.

She was wearing smooth black lace underneath, a matching set I'd never seen, a bra that pushed her tits up and together ,and underwear that was barely there, a thin scrap of thong. Julio's hands went immediately to her

body, sliding over her sides, her stomach, moving up to cup her tits through the cups.

This wasn't horse-play, this wasn't wrestling anymore. I swallowed hard but something about how they proceeded so rapidly to this, whatever this was now, made my mind swirl. I didn't know what was normal anymore.

I watched his hands on her, watched him squeeze and knead her, watched her arch into his touch, her head falling back with a small sound escaping her lips. Then his mouth was on her neck, kissing and licking, and she was still grinding on his lap, the movement more urgent now.

He reached around and unhooked her bra, the clasp giving way easily to his nimble, fast fingers. Jade shrugged it off her shoulders and let it fall before draping it over the back of the couch. She was topless in his lap, her chest bare. His hands covered them immediately, his palms rough against her soft skin, his fingers finding her nipples and rolling them, pinching them, and she gasped and ground down harder against him.

I couldn't look away, couldn't move, my beer forgotten in my hand, my own cock hard and straining against my jeans. I was going to say something about how her skin there is sensitive, to be careful, not so rough, she doesn't like that. But I watched as Julio bent his head and took her breast into his mouth, sucking and licking. Jade moaned, her hands going to his hair, gripping him there, her head falling back.

He switched to the other nipple, giving it the same attention, his hands on her hips now guiding her movement, making her grind against him in a rhythm he controlled. I could see the wet spot forming on his jeans, could see the evidence of how wet she was even through the layers of fabric between them.

Then he stood, lifting her with him, her legs wrapping around his waist automatically. He carried her the few steps to the other end of the couch and laid her down on her back, her head on the armrest and her body stretched out along the cushions.

He stood over her a moment, looking down at her nearly naked body the way it writhed and rolled. Then he hooked his fingers in the waistband of her underwear and pulled them down slowly, dragging them over her hips, down her thighs, past her knees, off her ankles, and placed them carefully over the back of the couch with her bra, her underwear like flags for me to watch.

She was completely naked now, spread out on our couch. I could see everything, could see how wet she was, could see the way her pussy glistened. Julio put his hands on her knees and pushed her legs up and wider apart, opening her up. And then he looked at me.

We made direct eye contact across the small room, his hands on my girlfriend's knees holding her legs spread wide. He said, "You good, man?" his voice casual like he was asking about taking a beer.

My mouth opened. I tried to speak, tried to form words, tried to say stop or no or anything, but nothing came out, but air and silence. I sat with my mouth hanging open like an idiot.

He took that as a yes.

He unbuckled his belt, the metal clinking, and unzipped his jeans, and pushed them down along with his boxers far enough to free his cock. It was big, much bigger than mine. I watched Jade's eyes go to it, watched her bite her lip, watched her legs spread even wider in reaction to the sight of it.

Julio stroked himself a few times, his hand moving up and down his cock, getting himself fully hard for my girl. Then he positioned himself between her legs, one knee on the couch and one foot on the floor. He guided his cock to her folds, rubbing the tip up and down through her, teasing her. She made a small desperate sound and her hips came up off the couch.

Then he pushed into her.

Slowly, inch by inch, I watched his long, thick cock disappear into my girlfriend, watched her lips stretch around him, watched her mouth fall open and her eyes shut closed and her hands grip the couch cushions till her knuckles turned white. He kept pushing until he was fully inside her, his hips pressed against hers now. He held himself deep inside her for a moment, buried completely, and she arched so deep under him, her face was pushed into the arm rest upside down behind her. She inhaled with a gasp the likes of which I never heard before.

Then he started moving on her.

He was slow at first, pulling almost all the way back out before pushing back in, long deep strokes that made Jade moan devilishly with each one, her hips moving from the force of his body. I watched his cock slide in and out of her, watched it come out coated with her juices, watched the way her body accepted him, folded around him, sucked him in.

He picked up speed, his hips moving faster now, thrusting into her harder. Jade's moans got louder, less controlled, her hands gripping the cushions and her head thrown back, her whole body rocking with the force of him fucking her.

I sat frozen in the chair watching another man fuck my girlfriend, watching her take his cock, watching her moan and writhe beneath him. My own cock was so hard it hurt, straining against my jeans. I couldn't stop watching, couldn't look away even though every second felt like it was burning something into my brain that I'd never be able to forget.

Julio changed position, pulling out of her completely. Jade made a sound of protest, but then he flipped her over, positioning her on her hands and knees on the couch, and he yanked her hips to pull her ass in the air facing him. He slapped it once, hard enough that the sound cracked through the apartment and left a red handprint on her skin, and she yelped and then moaned.

I never did that, I wouldn't dare do that.

He positioned himself behind her and pushed back inside her in one hard thrust. Jade's arms nearly gave out, she collapsed onto her elbows, her face pressing into the couch cushion. He started fucking her from behind, his hands on her hips pulling her back onto his cock with each thrust, the sound of skin slapping against skin filling the room along with her moans.

I could see everything from this angle, could see his cock pistoning in and out of her folds, could see the way her lips stretched around him, could see her pussy throb each time he went deep. I watched it all, unable to move, unable to speak, unable to do anything but watch.

Julio's hand slid up her back to her hair, gathering it in his fist and pulling her head back, arching her spine. I wanted to warn him not to hurt her like that. But he drove into her harder, faster. Jade was almost screaming now, loud uninhibited sounds of fucking. I knew the neighbors could probably hear but nobody cared, nobody was stopping this.

Then Jade's eyes flew open and she looked at me, turned her head enough to make eye contact with me while Julio fucked her from behind, while his cock was buried deep inside her. Her face was contorted and hungry and flushed and there was something in her eyes I couldn't read, something between pleasure and shame and defiance and need, and she held my gaze for maybe five seconds before her eyes rolled back and her whole body started shaking. "Sorry, Ryan," she managed to squeeze out.

Then her pussy clenched and spasmed around Julio's dick, and her moans turned into something closer to sobs. He didn't stop, he kept fucking her through it, kept his fist in her hair holding her head up and back so I could see her face as it grimaced and clenched. I watched her come on another man's cock, watched her whole body convulse with spasms, watched her completely fall apart.

I realized with a startle that until then, I'd never seen my girlfriend orgasm for real.

Julio pulled out suddenly and flipped her onto her back again, and before she'd fully recovered from her orgasm, he was pushing her legs up and back, nearly folding her in half, her knees by her shoulders, legs over his back. He slammed himself back inside her, deeper than before in this position. Jade cried out and slapped the cushions.

He fucked her like that, hard and fast and deep, her legs held up and spread wide, her pussy completely exposed and on display. I could see every detail, could see his cock stretching her wide, could see her pussy dripping, could see the way her whole body shook with each impact.

He lasted another few minutes like that before his rhythm got erratic, his movements less controlled. Then he was coming, pushing deep inside her one last time and holding himself there. I could see him pulsing, could see the moment he came inside her, filling her with his come. Jade was making small continuous sounds beneath him, completely overstimulated and overwhelmed.

He stayed inside her for a long moment, both of them breathing hard. Then he pulled out slowly and I could see his come gush from her pussy, could see the evidence of what had happened leaking out of my girlfriend down onto our couch.

Julio stood and pulled his boxers and jeans back up, zipping and buckling like he'd finished some normal activity. Jade stayed where she was on the couch, her legs still spread, her body still trembling, pussy still leaking from her orgasm, splayed like a boneless waste all over the couch.

He leaned down and kissed her, soft and almost tenderly, completely at odds with how roughly he'd just fucked her. Then he said, "See you tomorrow," like it was only another Friday night, like he'd be back for more tomorrow too.

Jade smiled up at him, dazed and satisfied, and said, "Yeah," her voice rough and quiet, and she made a kiss up to him.

Then he was pulling his coat on and heading for the door. He glanced at me one last time as he left, a quick look over his shoulder, an acknowledgment in his eyes. "Help her clean up?" he said softly, tenderly, to me. Then he was gone.

The apartment fell into silence except for the music still playing low from the speaker and Jade's breathing still heavy and ragged.

She was remained on the couch, naked, her legs still spread, come running between her thighs onto the cushions, her body flushed and marked and thoroughly fucked.

We looked at each other across the small space of our apartment, across the infinite distance that had opened between us.

My cock was still hard, still straining against my jeans. I could feel the wet spot where I'd come in my pants at some point during watching, though I couldn't remember when. She could probably see it, too, could see the evidence that I'd been turned on watching her get fucked so hard by another man.

She opened her mouth like she was going to say something but nothing came out, and she closed it again.

Instinctively I went for a soft towel, rinsed it in hot water, and brought it to her between her legs, because that was what I did after her and I finished.

"That's okay, that's okay," she said, and she took the towel and dashed to the bathroom with her hand cupped under herself between her legs.

"That's a bit too much," she laughed.

I came to the bathroom door and she looked down at my wet jeans. "Here, take those off," and so I did, and handed them to her. She ran them under the hot water, rinsing off my own come from them, and my shorts.

"I'll do laundry tomorrow," she said, and she dropped them in the bag for later.

In bed, she asked if I was sure I was okay. And then she leaned down and crawled between my legs and took me in her mouth. It was quick and perfunctory and she caught my spill in the same towel and chuckled about it. "There," she said, "even."

The next day we both agreed that that could not happen again. "Carried away, I guess," she said.

"I guess," I agreed.

"So..." she started up, apparently not finished with the topic as I thought we were. "But I don't want it to be a thing where I go up stairs."

There's other people up there, it's too embarrassing, they know about me and you and everything."

"No," I said. "I'd hate that too."

"Right? So down here. But Julio also said he didn't feel it was right to do it in front of you."

"Meaning?" The old familiar feeling of confusion, that numbness of the mind, that swirl of words and meanings, took over my head again.

"Like, put music on, maybe, and we can close the bedroom door...?"

"Our bedroom?"

She shook her head, raised her eyebrows, "No, no, I can change the sheets after, make a fresh bed for you and me."

The thought gripped me, what she was suggesting. But my cock, it grew hard again, too. She noticed, came to sit with me, pushed her hand down the front of my pants and wrapped her cool palm around it.

"We can hang out here a bit, and then when he, you know, wants to, you know Julio," she laughed and held her nose to stop herself. "He's a force and I am apparently a very movable object," she laughed. "As you know." She squeezed me, opened my pants. "You liked it, didn't you, though," she said in a secret voice.

"Jade," I said.

But she shh'd me, kissed me deeply with her tongue. "Don't be silly, I'll leave the door open a bit for you," she whispered in my ear. "Maybe I came so hard because I knew you were watching."

"Jade," I said again.

She tucked my cock away. "I'll suck you off and let you come in my mouth after," she said.

"No Jade," but she was already up and into the closet.

"Do you think he'd like this one?" she said, excitement in her voice, her eyebrows raised with anticipation. She was holding a blue flared skirt minidress up against her body.

I tried to form ideas, tried to make sentences. But she pinched my lips together. "It's for both of us, silly." She kissed me long and deeply. "Don't you know that by now?"

I sat on the bed before I crashed down to the floor.

"This one?" she repeated to me, kicking out the flare of the blue dress to let it brush back against her.

I only nodded.

“I think so too, he’s going to love it. But then white under it, right?” she said, and she opened her underwear draw and filched through it. She turned around naked, and held white lace thongs out to step into.

“Just don’t get weird when I bring him in here, okay?” she said, wiggling and setting the thin straps around her hips and squatting a bit to set the patch over herself right. “And wait a bit before I open the door for you to watch, so he doesn’t notice.”